

Q.3c (15 marks): How do descent theories and alliance theories differ in their approaches to understanding kinship...

4.c) How do descent theories and alliance theories differ in their approaches to understanding kinship and social organization? (15 marks)

As per Abercrombie - Kinship refers to social relations arising out of blood ties (real or fictive) or marriage.

Kinship is the basis of social organisation in terms of a cultural rule being applicable to economic, social, cultural, political, religious spheres of life.

It has been understood differently by Descent and Alliance theorists. Louis Dumont contrasted their approaches towards understanding social structure's basis.

① Descent Theorists

- traces in works of Radcliffe Brown
- later developed by Meyer Fortes and Evans Pritchard after study of African political systems.

② Basic idea

LevelUP IAS

③ castes

(Don't Write anything in this Area)

- They claim that unilineal descent groups form the backbone of society
- They function as corporate groups and regulate social, economic, political, religious spheres
- Thus, they contribute to social structure's stability and continuity

e.g. Nueres of South Sudan → divided into segmentary lineages. Each lineage/descent group shows unity and has a chief. They regulate their lineage and mediate disputes too.

② Alliance theorists

- Developed by Claude Lévi-Strauss & elaborated further by other structuralists like Edmund Leach

- View - alliances are the basis of ^{social} structure

Lucy Taboo → the marriage rule

ensures survival by resolving mutual hostility among groups - via "reciprocal exchange of women"

→ This reciprocal exchange form structure of marriage alliances that ensure society's continuity hence are called "Elementary Structures of Kinship" by Levi Strauss.

~~But its importance~~

Criticism

- Both theories emphasised more on just one out of "consanguinal" and "affinal" kin ignoring other
- Feminists criticised alliance theories for objectification of women
- Not all societies are unilineal — Descent theory has limited application

Contemporary Relevance

→ As individually, both represent partial view, both are necessary together to analyse kinship. Matrimonial alliances between kings (Mughal-Rajput, Princes-British), Descent loyalty of people even today makes both theories valid to understand complex social reality.

can write more points in both pages mentioned theories structure is not

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